

# Hamilton, ON to Yellowstone National Park Road Trip Itinerary

**Trip Duration:** July 4 – July 18, 2026 (15 Days, 14 Nights)  
**Travelers:** 2 Adults (Couple)  
**Vehicle:** Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

## Trip Overview

### Route Summary

- **Outbound Route:** Hamilton → Michigan → Wisconsin → South Dakota → Wyoming → Yellowstone
- **Return Route:** Yellowstone → South Dakota → Iowa → Illinois → Chicago (overnight) → Michigan → Ontario
- **Total Distance:** ~5,700 km round trip
- **National Parks Pass:** America the Beautiful Annual Pass — \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD) — Valid for 1 vehicle and all passengers

### Key Highlights

- Badlands & Wind Cave National Parks
- Mount Rushmore & Crazy Horse Memorial
- Devils Tower National Monument
- Grand Teton National Park (full dedicated day — Day 9)
- Lamar Valley wildlife corridor — wolves, bears, bison (Day 6 en route)
- Yellowstone National Park (3 nights)
- Chicago downtown overnight (Day 13)
- Multiple scenic drives with minimal trekking
- Cedar Rapids overnight option (flexible)

## Day-by-Day Itinerary

Day 1: Saturday, July 4, 2026

**Route:** Hamilton, ON → Mackinaw City, MI  
**Distance:** 650 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

**Canada Day Note:** This is now Independence Day in the USA — expect busier border crossings. Cross early.

### Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Hamilton 9:00 AM ET

- **Lunch Stop:** Windsor/Sarnia border crossing (~2 hours); cross into Detroit via Ambassador Bridge or Blue Water Bridge
- **Afternoon:** Drive through Michigan — optional quick stop at Port Huron beach
- **Evening:** Arrive Mackinaw City (~4:30 PM ET)
  - Walk along the waterfront
  - View Mackinac Bridge at sunset
  - Visit Colonial Michilimackinac State Park (if time permits)

 **Walking Distances — Mackinaw City**

| Viewpoint / Attraction            | Parking → Viewpoint         | Notes                                |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Mackinac Bridge viewpoint         | ~150 m from waterfront lot  | Flat, paved — easy stroll            |
| Colonial Michilimackinac entrance | ~100 m from park parking    | Compact grounds; ~500 m total inside |
| Port Huron beach (optional)       | ~50 m from roadside pullout | Drive-up access, minimal walking     |

 **Tip to reduce walking:** The bridge and waterfront are all within 200 m of each other — park once near the waterfront and walk to all three.

**Accommodation**

**Super 8 by Wyndham Mackinaw City**

Address: 519 S Nicolet St, Mackinaw City, MI 49701  
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, Wi-Fi  
Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

**Dining**

- **Lunch:** Border area — Tim Hortons or quick stop (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Mackinaw Grille, Mackinaw City — entrees \$15–25 USD/person (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

**Daily Cost Breakdown**

| Item                  | Cost (CAD)   |
|-----------------------|--------------|
| Accommodation         | \$131        |
| Meals                 | \$108        |
| Gas (~60L @ \$1.60/L) | \$96         |
| Border toll           | \$5          |
| <b>Daily Total</b>    | <b>\$340</b> |

Day 2: Sunday, July 5, 2026

**Route:** Mackinaw City, MI → Wisconsin Dells, WI  
**Distance:** 630 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:30 AM; cross Mackinac Bridge (\$4 USD toll)
- **En Route:** Drive through Upper Peninsula Michigan & Wisconsin; stop at Menominee River scenic overlook
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Wisconsin Dells (~3:00 PM CT)
  - Visit Mirror Lake State Park (free, natural beauty)
  - Walk through downtown Dells
  - Optional: Witches Gulch or Lost Canyon tours (\$15–20 USD pp)

 **Walking Distances — Wisconsin Dells**

| Viewpoint / Attraction          | Parking → Viewpoint             | Notes                 |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Mirror Lake State Park overlook | ~200 m from main lot            | Flat, paved path      |
| Downtown Dells main strip       | ~100 m from street parking      | Compact, walkable     |
| Witches Gulch (optional)        | ~500 m one-way boat + boardwalk | Mostly flat boardwalk |
| Lost Canyon (optional)          | ~600 m canyon walk              | Flat canyon floor     |

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Skip Witches Gulch/Lost Canyon if tired — the downtown stroll and Mirror Lake are fully scenic with under 400 m walking total.

Accommodation

**Days Inn by Wyndham Wisconsin Dells**  
Address: 944 Highway 13, Wisconsin Dells, WI 53965  
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, outdoor pool  
Rate: \$88 USD/night (~\$121 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Wisconsin (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co. (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$121      |
| Meals                 | \$106      |
| Gas (~57L @ \$1.60/L) | \$91       |

| Item                     | Cost (CAD)                 |
|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| Mackinac Bridge toll     | \$6                        |
| Optional tour (if taken) | \$55                       |
| Daily Total              | \$324 (or \$379 with tour) |

Day 3: Monday, July 6, 2026

**Route:** Wisconsin Dells, WI → Rapid City, SD

**Distance:** 770 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:00 AM CT; drive through Minnesota & South Dakota
- **Lunch:** Mitchell, SD — see the Corn Palace (free, quirky roadside attraction)
- **Evening:** Arrive Rapid City (~4:30 PM MT)
  - Walk around downtown Rapid City
  - City of Presidents walking tour (free bronze statues)

 **Walking Distances — Rapid City**

| Viewpoint / Attraction               | Parking → Viewpoint         | Notes                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Corn Palace exterior (Mitchell)      | ~50 m from street parking   | Roadside — minimal walking                                                           |
| City of Presidents statues, downtown | ~100 m from Main St parking | Statues are spread ~1 km along streets; do a short loop of 4–5 closest ones (~400 m) |

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Drive the City of Presidents route slowly and hop out only for statues that interest you most — all are within 50 m of the road.

Accommodation

**Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City**

Address: 1314 N Elk Vale Rd, Rapid City, SD 57703  
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool  
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Corn Palace Café, Mitchell, SD (~\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Tally's Silver Spoon, Rapid City (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$145      |
| Meals                 | \$97       |
| Gas (~70L @ \$1.60/L) | \$112      |
| Daily Total           | \$354      |

Day 4: Tuesday, July 7, 2026

**Route:** Rapid City, SD (Day Trip Loop)  
**Distance:** 240 km loop | **Driving Time:** 5 hours total (with stops)

Attractions & Stops — FULL DAY OF SIGHTSEEING

Morning:

- **Mount Rushmore National Memorial** (1.5–2 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass (otherwise \$10 parking)
- **Custer State Park** (2–3 hours) — Wildlife Loop Road scenic drive; Needles Highway; Sylvan Lake area — Entry: \$20 USD/vehicle (~\$28 CAD)

Afternoon:

- **Crazy Horse Memorial** (1 hour) — Entry: \$15 USD/person (~\$41 CAD for two)
- Return to Rapid City via Iron Mountain Road (scenic tunnels framing Mount Rushmore)

 **Walking Distances — Day 4 Sightseeing**

| Attraction                          | Parking Location                   | Walk to Main Viewpoint             | Notes                                                     |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Mount Rushmore — Grand View Terrace | Main visitor parking               | ~250 m from parking to terrace     | Paved, gentle incline; <b>this is all you need</b>        |
| Mount Rushmore — Presidential Trail | Same parking                       | ~800 m loop (adds closer views)    | Optional; mostly flat with some steps — skip if preferred |
| Custer State Park — Wildlife Loop   | Drive-in scenic road               | <b>0 m — view from car windows</b> | Bison, pronghorn, burros roadside                         |
| Needles Highway granite spires      | Cathedral Spires trailhead pullout | ~0–50 m roadside pullouts          | Drive-through; tunnels are the main attraction            |
| Sylvan Lake (optional)              | Sylvan Lake parking                | ~300 m easy lakeside loop          | Flat, paved — very scenic; skip if short on time          |
| Crazy Horse Memorial                | Visitor center lot                 | ~100 m to terrace viewpoint        | All viewing from terrace; no trail needed                 |

| Attraction                            | Parking Location  | Walk to Main Viewpoint | Notes                                                      |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Iron Mountain Road<br>pigtail bridges | Roadside pullouts | ~0–100 m from car      | Drive slowly and stop at tunnels for framed Rushmore views |

 **Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 4:**

1. Mount Rushmore → walk only to Grand View Terrace (250 m, ~10 min) — skip Presidential Trail
2. Drive Wildlife Loop Road in Custer SP (pure car experience)
3. Drive Needles Highway — stop at 2–3 pullouts only (under 100 m each)
4. Crazy Horse → terrace viewpoint (100 m)
5. Iron Mountain Road back — tunnel photo stops only

**Total walking for the day: under 700 m** while seeing everything.

**Accommodation**

**Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City** (same as previous night)  
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

**Dining**

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** State Game Lodge, Custer State Park — buffalo burger! (~\$45 USD / ~\$62 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Murphy's Pub & Grill, Rapid City (~\$48 USD / ~\$66 CAD for two)

**Daily Cost Breakdown**

| Item                    | Cost (CAD)   |
|-------------------------|--------------|
| Accommodation           | \$145        |
| Meals                   | \$128        |
| Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)   | \$35         |
| Custer State Park entry | \$28         |
| Crazy Horse entry       | \$41         |
| <b>Daily Total</b>      | <b>\$377</b> |

Day 5: Wednesday, July 8, 2026

**Route:** Rapid City, SD → Cody, WY  
**Distance:** 560 km | **Driving Time:** 6 hours

**Attractions & Stops**

**Morning:**

- **Badlands National Park** (2–3 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
  - Drive Badlands Loop Road (Hwy 240) — 31 miles of scenic overlooks
  - Stop at: Pinnacles Overlook, Yellow Mounds, Panorama Point, Big Badlands Overlook

#### Afternoon:

- **Devils Tower National Monument** (1.5 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
- **Evening:** Arrive Cody, WY

#### Walking Distances — Day 5 Sightseeing

| Attraction                                       | Parking Location              | Walk to Viewpoint         | Notes                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Badlands — Big Badlands Overlook                 | Roadside pullout              | <b>~30 m from car</b>     | Best panoramic view; drive-up                                                    |
| Badlands — Pinnacles Overlook                    | Pinnacles Overlook lot        | ~50 m from car            | Flat gravel path                                                                 |
| Badlands — Yellow Mounds Overlook                | Roadside pullout              | <b>~20 m from car</b>     | Drive-up pullout                                                                 |
| Badlands — Panorama Point                        | Small lot                     | ~50 m from car            | Flat, paved                                                                      |
| Badlands — Door Trail boardwalk (optional)       | Ben Reifel Visitor Center lot | 0.75 km boardwalk (flat)  | Fully accessible; great canyon views                                             |
| Badlands — Fossil Exhibit Trail (optional)       | Fossil Exhibit pullout        | 0.4 km paved loop         | Fully flat; fossils under glass                                                  |
| Devils Tower — viewpoint from parking area       | Tower Trail lot               | ~200 m to best view angle | Flat paved path                                                                  |
| Devils Tower — Red Beds Trail partial (optional) | Same lot                      | 1.5 km partial loop       | Mostly flat; great alternate angles — <b>do first 400 m only for extra views</b> |

#### Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 5:

- Badlands: Drive Loop Road and stop at 4–5 pullouts (all under 50 m from car). Add Door Trail boardwalk only if energized (0.75 km flat).
- Devils Tower: Walk 200 m to main viewpoint from parking. Optionally add 400 m of Red Beds for tower-close view. Skip full loop.
- **Total walking: 400–900 m for the full day.**

#### Accommodation

##### Hampton Inn Cody

Address: 1807 Sheridan Ave, Cody, WY 82414

Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool  
Rate: \$115 USD/night (~\$159 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Cedar Pass Lodge, Badlands or packed sandwiches (~\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wyoming's Rib & Chop House, Cody (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD)   |
|-----------------------|--------------|
| Accommodation         | \$159        |
| Meals                 | \$118        |
| Gas (~51L @ \$1.60/L) | \$82         |
| <b>Daily Total</b>    | <b>\$359</b> |

Day 6: Thursday, July 9, 2026

**Route:** Cody, WY → Lamar Valley → Yellowstone Lake Overlook → West Yellowstone, MT  
**Distance:** 343 km | **Driving Time:** ~5h 10min (per Google Maps, via WY-296 & US-212 W)

**Route Note:** This is the scenic Beartooth Highway approach entering Yellowstone through the **Northeast Entrance** via Cooke City, MT — considered one of the most spectacular drives in North America. You'll pass through Lamar Valley mid-route then exit via the park's south end past Yellowstone Lake before arriving at West Yellowstone. Note: this route has tolls (Northeast Entrance park fee — covered by your America the Beautiful Pass). Fill up gas in Cody before departing as there are limited stations on this mountain route.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- **Buffalo Bill Center of the West**, Cody (2 hours max — keep it brief to allow time for the drive) — Entry: \$21 USD/person (~\$58 CAD for two)
- Depart Cody by 10:00 AM; head north on WY-296 (Chief Joseph Scenic Byway)

Mid-Morning:

- **Chief Joseph Scenic Byway / WY-296** — dramatic canyon and mountain scenery; roadside pullouts along the way
- Enter Yellowstone via **Northeast Entrance** (near Cooke City, MT)

Late Morning – Early Afternoon:

- 🐾 **Lamar Valley** — "Serengeti of North America" (1.5–2 hours)
  - Best wildlife viewing in all of Yellowstone: bison herds, wolves, bears, elk, pronghorn



- View entirely from car and roadside pullouts — no hiking needed
- Drive the full Lamar Valley stretch slowly (~30 km); stop at pullouts as wildlife appears
- **This is the best time of day for wildlife — late morning light is ideal**

#### Afternoon:

- Continue south through the park (Tower Junction → Canyon → Fishing Bridge)
- **Yellowstone Lake Overlook Trail area** — pullouts along the north shore of Yellowstone Lake
  - Lake Butte Overlook: stunning panoramic view over the lake (drive-up)
  - Fishing Bridge area: pelicans, osprey, cutthroat trout visible from bridge (walk across bridge — ~200 m)

#### Evening:

- Exit via West Entrance; arrive West Yellowstone (~5:30–6:00 PM)
- Walk around town, visit shops

#### Walking Distances — Day 6

| Attraction                             | Parking Location                                 | Walk to Viewpoint            | Notes                                          |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Buffalo Bill Center of the West        | On-site lot                                      | ~50 m to entrance            | All indoor — keep visit to 2 hrs max           |
| Chief Joseph Scenic Byway pullouts     | Roadside pullouts                                | ~20–50 m from car            | Mountain canyon views; drive-up                |
| Lamar Valley wildlife viewing          | Multiple roadside pullouts along Lamar Valley Rd | <b>0–30 m from car</b>       | Stay in or beside car; bison may approach road |
| Fishing Bridge                         | Fishing Bridge parking area                      | ~200 m across bridge (flat)  | Watch for osprey and pelicans from the bridge  |
| Yellowstone Lake — Lake Butte Overlook | Roadside pullout (East Entrance Rd)              | ~30–50 m from car            | Best lake panorama; completely drive-up        |
| West Yellowstone town stroll           | Hotel parking                                    | ~100–200 m along Madison Ave | Flat, relaxed evening walk                     |

 **Optimized Tip for Day 6:** Lamar Valley is 100% a car-window and roadside experience — you don't need to leave the vehicle at all unless you spot wildlife at a pullout. Budget 90 minutes to drive slowly through the full valley, stopping wherever herds appear. This maximises sightings with zero walking effort.

#### Accommodation

##### Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone

Address: 209 Madison Ave, West Yellowstone, MT 59758

Features: Level 2 EV charging (ChargePoint), free breakfast, hot tub

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

#### Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel; eat early before departing
- **Lunch:** Pack sandwiches from hotel / grab in Cody before departure — limited options inside the Northeast entrance (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wild West Pizzeria & Saloon, West Yellowstone (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                                 | Cost (CAD) |
|--------------------------------------|------------|
| Accommodation                        | \$186      |
| Meals                                | \$101      |
| Gas (~31L @ \$1.60/L — longer route) | \$50       |
| Buffalo Bill Center entry            | \$58       |
| Daily Total                          | \$395      |

Day 7: Friday, July 10, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 1 (Lower Loop)  
Distance: 150 km in park | Driving Time: Full day with stops

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Enter Yellowstone West Entrance (7:00 AM — beat crowds!)
- **Lower Geyser Basin — Fountain Paint Pot**
- **Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring**
- **Old Faithful area**

Afternoon:

- **West Thumb Geyser Basin** on Yellowstone Lake
- Drive along Yellowstone Lake shore
- **Lake Butte Overlook**

Evening: Return to West Yellowstone

 Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 1

| Attraction                             | Parking Location       | Walk to Main Viewpoint    | Full Loop          | Recommendation                                                    |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fountain Paint Pot, Lower Geyser Basin | Fountain Paint Pot lot | ~100 m to boardwalk start | 0.8 km loop (flat) | ✅ <b>Do the full loop</b> — all flat boardwalk, multiple features |

| Attraction                                  | Parking Location                            | Walk to Main Viewpoint       | Full Loop                     | Recommendation                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Grand Prismatic Spring, Midway Geyser Basin | Midway Geyser Basin lot                     | ~50 m to boardwalk           | 0.8 km loop (flat)            | ✅ <b>Do the full loop</b> — THE highlight, completely flat                                                        |
| Grand Prismatic Overlook Trail (optional)   | Fairy Falls trailhead, 0.8 km south         | 1.3 km uphill each way       | —                             | ⚠️ <b>Skip</b> — aerial view is great but significant uphill; the boardwalk at ground level is equally impressive |
| Old Faithful Geyser                         | Old Faithful Visitor Center lot             | ~200 m to viewing benches    | —                             | ✅ Watch from benches — 200 m flat walk from car                                                                   |
| Upper Geyser Basin boardwalk                | Old Faithful lot                            | ~200 m to start of boardwalk | 1–3 km depending on extension | ✅ <b>Do first 800 m</b> to Beehive/Castle/Riverside Geysers; skip extension to Morning Glory Pool (adds 2 km)     |
| Morning Glory Pool (optional extension)     | Old Faithful lot                            | ~2.4 km one-way              | —                             | ⚠️ <b>Skip</b> — pool is beautiful but very long walk; not worth it on a packed day                               |
| West Thumb Geyser Basin                     | West Thumb lot                              | ~50 m to boardwalk           | 0.9 km loop (flat)            | ✅ <b>Do the full loop</b> — lakeside thermal features, fully flat                                                 |
| Lake Butte Overlook                         | Roadside pullout (6 km past fishing bridge) | ~50 m from car               | —                             | ✅ Drive-up viewpoint                                                                                              |

### ● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 7:

1. Fountain Paint Pot — 0.8 km flat loop ✅
2. Grand Prismatic Spring — 0.8 km flat loop ✅ (skip overlook trail)
3. Old Faithful — 200 m to benches; watch eruption ✅
4. Upper Geyser Basin — walk 800 m only (to Riverside Geyser) ✅
5. West Thumb Geyser Basin — 0.9 km flat loop ✅
6. Lake Butte Overlook — drive-up ✅

**Total walking: ~3.5 km** across the entire day (all flat boardwalks).

### Accommodation

**Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone** (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

### Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Packed sandwiches/snacks (buy groceries evening before) (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Running Bear Pancake House, West Yellowstone (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                   | Cost (CAD)   |
|------------------------|--------------|
| Accommodation          | \$186        |
| Meals                  | \$94         |
| Gas (~14L @ \$1.60/L)  | \$22         |
| Groceries for next day | \$30         |
| <b>Daily Total</b>     | <b>\$332</b> |

Day 8: Saturday, July 11, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 2 (Upper Loop)

**Distance:** 180 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

**Note:** July 4th has passed — this weekend is still peak summer but crowds are more manageable. Start early (6:00 AM) regardless.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Depart 6:00 AM
- **Norris Geyser Basin**
- **Mammoth Hot Springs**

Afternoon:

- **Tower-Roosevelt area** (scenic drive)
- **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone**

Evening:

- **Hayden Valley** — prime wildlife viewing

 Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 2

| Attraction                            | Parking Location | Walk to Main Viewpoint    | Full Option        | Recommendation                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------|------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Norris Geyser Basin — Porcelain Basin | Norris lot       | ~100 m to boardwalk start | 0.8 km loop (flat) |  <b>Do Porcelain Basin loop</b> — the most dramatic, all flat |

| Attraction                                     | Parking Location                    | Walk to Main Viewpoint         | Full Option               | Recommendation                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Norris Geyser Basin — Back Basin               | Same lot                            | ~150 m to boardwalk start      | 1.5 km loop (mostly flat) | ⚠️ <b>Optional</b> — skip or do first 400 m to Steamboat Geyser only                            |
| Mammoth Hot Springs — Lower Terraces           | Lower Terraces lot                  | ~50 m to boardwalk             | 0.6 km loop (flat)        | ✅ <b>Do the Lower Terraces</b> — most colourful, fully flat                                     |
| Mammoth Hot Springs — Upper Terraces           | Upper Terraces one-way road (drive) | ~100 m per pullout             | Drive-through loop        | ✅ <b>Drive the one-way upper terrace road</b> — park at pullouts, walk 50–100 m to each terrace |
| Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point     | Artist Point lot                    | ~150 m paved path to viewpoint | —                         | ✅ <b>Must-do</b> — iconic falls view, 150 m flat walk                                           |
| Grand Canyon — Lookout Point                   | North Rim lot                       | ~200 m to canyon rim           | —                         | ✅ Great secondary view, 200 m easy walk                                                         |
| Grand Canyon — Brink of Lower Falls (optional) | Brink lot                           | 0.5 km downhill then back up   | —                         | ⚠️ <b>Skip</b> — steep and strenuous; Artist Point gives equal drama                            |
| Uncle Tom's Trail                              | South Rim lot                       | 328 steps down + back up       | —                         | ❌ <b>Skip</b> — very strenuous                                                                  |
| Hayden Valley wildlife pullouts                | Multiple roadside pullouts          | <b>0–30 m from car</b>         | —                         | ✅ View bison herds from car or roadside                                                         |

### ● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 8:

1. Norris — Porcelain Basin loop (0.8 km flat) ✅
2. Mammoth — Lower Terraces loop (0.6 km flat) + drive Upper Terraces ✅
3. Grand Canyon — Artist Point (150 m) + Lookout Point (200 m) ✅
4. Hayden Valley — wildlife from car windows ✅

**Total walking: ~1.8 km** for the entire day.

### Accommodation

**Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone** (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

### Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel (early buffet)
- **Lunch:** Packed lunch from groceries (\$0 — already purchased)
- **Dinner:** Serenity Bistro, West Yellowstone (~\$58 USD / ~\$80 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$186      |
| Meals                 | \$80       |
| Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L) | \$26       |
| Daily Total           | \$292      |

Day 9: Sunday, July 12, 2026

GRAND TETON — Full Day

**Route:** West Yellowstone → Grand Teton National Park → Jackson, WY

**Distance:** ~180 km | **Driving Time:** ~2.5 hours driving + full day in park

**Day 9 Focus:** With Lamar Valley now done on Day 6, today is entirely devoted to **Grand Teton National Park** — giving you a leisurely full day to enjoy the most photogenic mountain scenery in the American West without rushing. You'll enter the park from the north (from Yellowstone's South Entrance) and work your way south to Jackson, hitting every iconic viewpoint along the way at your own pace.

Attractions & Stops

Morning (depart West Yellowstone 7:30 AM):

- Drive south from West Yellowstone through Yellowstone's south section (~1.5 hrs)
- Enter Grand Teton National Park via **North Entrance (Moran Junction)**
- **Oxbow Bend** — first stop; stunning Teton reflection in still water, especially beautiful in morning light
- **Signal Mountain Summit Road** (*optional — 8 km paved side road, drive to top*) — panoramic 360° view of the entire Teton Range and Jackson Hole Valley from above; completely driveable to summit

Mid-Morning:

- **Jenny Lake** — allow 45–60 minutes here
  - Walk to lakefront for the classic Teton-over-water reflection shot (~200 m from South lot)
  - Optional: sit at the lakeside benches and enjoy the view — no rush today
  - Optional: Jenny Lake Visitor Center (free, small but worthwhile)
- **String Lake Picnic Area** — beautiful spot for a mid-morning snack break; calm lake, Teton backdrop

Late Morning – Lunch:

- **Schwabacher Landing** — drive the short dirt road to the river; iconic beaver pond reflection of the Tetons (~200 m flat walk from lot)

- **Lunch at Dornan's in Moose** — casual outdoor patio with one of the best Teton views from any restaurant (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)

#### Afternoon:

- **Snake River Overlook** — the Ansel Adams viewpoint; roadside pullout, ~30 m walk, unmissable
- **Mormon Row Historic District** — T.A. Moulton Barn with the Tetons rising behind it; one of the most photographed spots in the USA. Walk to the barns (~50–150 m from roadside parking)
- **Antelope Flats Road** — slow drive through open sage flats; excellent pronghorn, bison, and bald eagle sightings from the car
- **National Museum of Wildlife Art** (optional, Jackson) — Entry ~\$15 USD pp; stunning building perched above the National Elk Refuge; architecture alone is worth the stop

#### Late Afternoon – Evening:

- Arrive **Jackson** (~4:00–5:00 PM)
- Walk Jackson Town Square (elk antler arches) — ~5 min from hotel
- Browse galleries and shops on Broadway/Cache St
- Enjoy a relaxed dinner

#### Walking Distances — Grand Teton Full Day

| Attraction              | Parking Location                              | Walk to Main Viewpoint    | Full Option                      | Recommendation                                                  |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Oxbow Bend              | Roadside pullout (Hwy 89, north of Moran Jct) | <b>~30 m from car</b>     | —                                | ✓ Drive-up; best in morning light                               |
| Signal Mountain Summit  | Signal Mountain Summit lot                    | <b>0 m — drive to top</b> | Short 50 m walk to overlook rail | ✓ Completely driveable; do it — extraordinary 360° view         |
| Jenny Lake lakefront    | Jenny Lake South lot                          | ~200 m to water's edge    | 3.9 km loop (skip)               | ✓ Walk 200 m to lakefront only; spend time sitting and enjoying |
| String Lake Picnic Area | String Lake lot                               | ~100 m to lakeshore       | —                                | ✓ Gentle flat walk; great snack/rest stop                       |
| Schwabacher Landing     | Schwabacher Rd dirt lot                       | ~200 m to beaver ponds    | —                                | ✓ Flat gravel; best reflection photography in park              |
| Dornan's Patio, Moose   | Dornan's lot                                  | ~50 m to restaurant patio | —                                | ✓ Lunch with unbeatable Teton view                              |
| Snake River Overlook    | Roadside pullout (Hwy 89)                     | <b>~30 m from car</b>     | —                                | ✓ Iconic Ansel Adams spot; drive-up                             |

| Attraction                                 | Parking Location      | Walk to Main Viewpoint  | Full Option           | Recommendation                                            |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Mormon Row — T.A. Moulton Barn             | Roadside dirt parking | ~100–150 m to main barn | ~300 m to second barn | ✓ Flat dirt path; walk to both barns for different angles |
| Antelope Flats Road wildlife drive         | Drive-through         | 0 m — car windows       | —                     | ✓ Pure car experience; pronghorn and bison roadside       |
| National Museum of Wildlife Art (optional) | Museum lot            | ~100 m to entrance      | Indoor                | ⚠ Optional; great if you enjoy wildlife art; \$15 USD pp  |
| Jackson Town Square                        | Town Square lot       | ~50 m to antler arches  | —                     | ✓ Quick and flat; nice evening stroll                     |

● **Optimized Full-Day Grand Teton Route (North → South, no backtracking):**

- 1. Oxbow Bend — 30 m walk, morning reflection ✓
- 2. Signal Mountain Summit — drive to top, 50 m to overlook ✓
- 3. Jenny Lake — 200 m lakefront walk + rest ✓
- 4. Schwabacher Landing — 200 m flat walk ✓
- 5. Dornan's lunch — 50 m walk ✓
- 6. Snake River Overlook — 30 m walk ✓
- 7. Mormon Row — 150 m walk to barns ✓
- 8. Antelope Flats — car windows ✓
- 9. Arrive Jackson — evening stroll ✓

**Total walking: ~1,010 m** across 8 iconic spots — a deeply satisfying full day with under 1.1 km of walking total.

**Accommodation**

**Elk Country Inn — Jackson Hole**

Address: 480 W Pearl Ave, Jackson, WY 83001  
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi  
Rate: \$125 USD/night (~\$172 CAD)

**Dining**

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel; eat before departing
- **Lunch:** Dornan's Patio, Moose, WY — outdoor patio with Teton views (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Bubba's Bar-B-Que, Jackson — classic Western BBQ (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

**Daily Cost Breakdown**



| Item                                 | Cost (CAD)                   |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Accommodation                        | \$172                        |
| Meals                                | \$131                        |
| Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)                | \$26                         |
| Optional: Wildlife Art Museum (2 pp) | \$41                         |
| Daily Total                          | \$329 (or \$370 with museum) |

Day 10: Monday, July 13, 2026

**Route:** Jackson, WY → Custer, SD  
**Distance:** 750 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Jackson 8:00 AM; quick walk around Jackson Town Square (elk antler arches)
- **En Route:** Long driving day through Wyoming and into South Dakota; lunch stop in Lusk or Newcastle, WY
- **Afternoon:** Wind Cave National Park (if time permits — 1–2 hours) — Entry included; cave tours \$15 USD pp
- **Evening:** Arrive Custer, SD

 Walking Distances — Day 10

| Attraction                            | Parking Location   | Walk to Viewpoint                     | Notes                |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------|
| Jackson Town Square elk antler arches | Town Square lot    | ~50 m to square centre                | Quick and flat       |
| Wind Cave NP — prairie dog viewpoint  | Visitor center lot | ~100 m to overlook                    | Optional; flat path  |
| Wind Cave NP — cave tour (optional)   | Visitor center lot | Guided tour only (0.8 km underground) | Book ahead; moderate |

Accommodation

**Comfort Inn & Suites Custer**  
Address: 340 W Mt Rushmore Rd, Custer, SD 57730  
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, indoor pool  
Rate: \$98 USD/night (~\$135 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside diner in Wyoming (~\$35 CAD)

- **Dinner:** Skogen Kitchen, Custer (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$135      |
| Meals                 | \$104      |
| Gas (~68L @ \$1.60/L) | \$109      |
| Daily Total           | \$348      |

Day 11: Tuesday, July 14, 2026

**Route:** Custer, SD → Sioux Falls, SD  
**Distance:** 450 km | **Driving Time:** 4.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Revisit any Rapid City/Mount Rushmore area OR depart directly ~9:00 AM
- **En Route:** Stop at Mitchell Corn Palace (if missed earlier)
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Sioux Falls (~2:00 PM); visit Falls Park and SculptureWalk
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

 Walking Distances — Sioux Falls

| Attraction                          | Parking Location     | Walk to Viewpoint                | Notes                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Falls Park main waterfall viewpoint | Falls Park lot       | ~200 m to upper viewing platform | Flat, paved                                                                    |
| Falls Park lower level views        | Same lot             | ~400 m to river level paths      | Gentle descent                                                                 |
| SculptureWalk, downtown             | Phillips Ave parking | ~50 m to first sculpture         | Sculptures every 50–100 m along ~1 km of Phillips Ave; walk as far as you like |

 **Tip:** The Falls Park upper platform (200 m from car) gives the best single view of all the falls at once — get that shot and you're done in under 15 minutes if needed.

Accommodation

**La Quinta Inn & Suites Sioux Falls**  
Address: 4520 E Arrowhead Pkwy, Sioux Falls, SD 57110  
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast  
Rate: \$92 USD/night (~\$127 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route stop (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** JL Beers, Sioux Falls — burgers & craft beer (~\$48 USD / ~\$66 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$127      |
| Meals                 | \$96       |
| Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L) | \$66       |
| Daily Total           | \$289      |

Day 12: Wednesday, July 15, 2026

**Route:** Sioux Falls, SD → Des Moines, IA  
**Distance:** 400 km | **Driving Time:** 4 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Sioux Falls 9:00 AM; drive through Iowa farmland
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Des Moines (~1:00 PM); Iowa State Capitol tour (free); Pappajohn Sculpture Park (free); East Village shopping
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

 Walking Distances — Des Moines

| Attraction                  | Parking Location      | Walk to Viewpoint    | Notes                                                |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Iowa State Capitol exterior | Capitol lot           | ~100 m to main steps | Flat, paved; interior tours also available           |
| Pappajohn Sculpture Park    | Park lot on Grand Ave | ~50 m to park entry  | 4.4-acre park; walk as little or as much as you like |

Accommodation

Hampton Inn & Suites Des Moines Downtown

Address: 120 SW Water St, Des Moines, IA 50309  
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast  
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop (~\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Zombie Burger + Drink Lab, Des Moines (~\$45 USD / ~\$62 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Accommodation         | \$145      |
| Meals                 | \$90       |
| Gas (~36L @ \$1.60/L) | \$58       |
| Daily Total           | \$293      |

Day 13: Thursday, July 16, 2026

**Route:** Des Moines, IA → Chicago, IL  
**Distance:** 530 km | **Driving Time:** 5.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Des Moines 8:00 AM; lunch stop in Moline or Rock Island, IL
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Chicago (~2:00 PM)
  - **Millennium Park** — Cloud Gate "The Bean" (free)
  - Chicago Riverwalk
  - Navy Pier (free to walk)
- **Evening:** Dinner in Chicago; optional 360 Chicago or Skydeck Willis Tower (~\$30 USD pp / ~\$82 CAD for two)

 Walking Distances — Chicago

| Attraction                                    | Parking / Transit             | Walk to Main Viewpoint                   | Notes                                |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Cloud Gate "The Bean", Millennium Park        | Michigan Ave garage or street | ~300 m from nearest garage to Cloud Gate | Flat, paved — easy stroll            |
| Chicago Riverwalk                             | Wacker Dr parking             | ~100 m to Riverwalk entry                | Walk as far as desired; 1–3 km flat  |
| Navy Pier entrance                            | Navy Pier garage              | ~100 m to pier entrance                  | Drive-up; walk along pier as desired |
| 360 Chicago / Willis Tower Skydeck (optional) | Street or garage nearby       | ~100–200 m from parking                  | Indoor elevator — no walking concern |

 **Tip:** Park once in the Grant Park / Millennium Park garages — you can walk to The Bean, Riverwalk, and waterfront all within 500 m of each other without moving the car.

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Chicago Downtown/N Loop/Michigan Ave

Address: 68 E Wacker Pl, Chicago, IL 60601  
Features: Level 2 EV charging nearby, free breakfast, central location  
Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Illinois (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Giordano's or Lou Malnati's — Chicago deep dish pizza! (~\$65 USD / ~\$90 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                      | Cost (CAD)                             |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Accommodation             | \$200                                  |
| Meals                     | \$120                                  |
| Gas (~48L @ \$1.60/L)     | \$77                                   |
| Optional observation deck | \$82                                   |
| Parking (if needed)       | \$40                                   |
| Daily Total               | \$437 (or \$519 with observation deck) |

Day 14: Friday, July 17, 2026

**Route:** Chicago, IL → Kalamazoo, MI  
**Distance:** 240 km | **Driving Time:** 3 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Leisurely breakfast; final walk around Chicago; optional Art Institute or Architecture River Cruise; depart 10:00 AM
- **En Route:** Drive along Lake Michigan shore through Indiana; **Indiana Dunes National Park** (optional 1–2 hour stop) — Entry included
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Kalamazoo (~2:00 PM); walk around downtown; Kalamazoo Valley Museum (free)

 Walking Distances — Day 14

| Attraction                               | Parking Location              | Walk to Main Viewpoint      | Notes                                       |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Indiana Dunes — Lake View beach          | West Beach lot                | ~400 m to water's edge      | Flat sand path                              |
| Indiana Dunes — dune overlook (optional) | West Beach or Kemil Beach lot | 0.5–1 km depending on trail | Some gentle climbing — <b>skip if tired</b> |

| Attraction                   | Parking Location            | Walk to Main Viewpoint         | Notes                       |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Kalamazoo Valley Museum      | Museum lot on Kalamazoo Ave | ~50 m to entrance              | Indoor — no terrain concern |
| Downtown Kalamazoo walkabout | Burdick St parking          | ~100 m to main pedestrian zone | Flat, walkable              |

 **Tip:** At Indiana Dunes, drive to Kemil Beach instead of West Beach — shorter walk (~150 m) to a beautiful Lake Michigan shoreline with good dune views.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Kalamazoo

Address: 3800 Easy St, Portage, MI 49002  
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast  
Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route in Indiana (~\$32 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Bell's Brewery, Kalamazoo — local craft brewery & pub (~\$52 USD / ~\$72 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD)   |
|-----------------------|--------------|
| Accommodation         | \$131        |
| Meals                 | \$104        |
| Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L) | \$35         |
| <b>Daily Total</b>    | <b>\$270</b> |

Day 15: Saturday, July 18, 2026

**Route:** Kalamazoo, MI → Hamilton, ON  
**Distance:** 450 km | **Driving Time:** 5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Final hotel breakfast; depart Kalamazoo 9:00 AM
- **En Route:** Drive through Michigan toward Canadian border; cross at Detroit/Windsor or Port Huron/Sarnia
- **Afternoon:** Arrive HOME in Hamilton! (~2:00–3:00 PM ET)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Border area or back home! (~\$25 CAD)

Daily Cost Breakdown

| Item                  | Cost (CAD) |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Meals                 | \$25       |
| Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L) | \$66       |
| Border crossing       | \$5        |
| Daily Total           | \$96       |

Complete Cost Breakdown Summary

Accommodation (14 nights)

| Location             | Nights | Total CAD |
|----------------------|--------|-----------|
| Mackinaw City, MI    | 1      | \$131     |
| Wisconsin Dells, WI  | 1      | \$121     |
| Rapid City, SD       | 2      | \$290     |
| Cody, WY             | 1      | \$159     |
| West Yellowstone, MT | 3      | \$572     |
| Jackson, WY          | 1      | \$172     |
| Custer, SD           | 1      | \$135     |
| Sioux Falls, SD      | 1      | \$127     |
| Des Moines, IA       | 1      | \$145     |
| Chicago, IL          | 1      | \$200     |
| Kalamazoo, MI        | 1      | \$131     |
| TOTAL ACCOMMODATION  | 14     | \$2,183   |

Meals (15 days)

Average per day: \$98 CAD  
**TOTAL MEALS: \$1,470 CAD**

Fuel (5,700 km total)

Estimated consumption: 530 litres total  
Rate: \$1.60/L CAD average  
**TOTAL FUEL: \$848 CAD**

Park Entries & Attractions

| Attraction                        | Cost CAD                                             |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| America the Beautiful Annual Pass | \$110                                                |
| Custer State Park                 | \$28                                                 |
| Crazy Horse Memorial              | \$41                                                 |
| Buffalo Bill Center               | \$58                                                 |
| Chicago parking (1 day)           | \$40                                                 |
| Bridge/border tolls               | \$20                                                 |
| Optional Wisconsin Dells tour     | \$55                                                 |
| Optional Chicago observation deck | \$82                                                 |
| <b>TOTAL ENTRIES</b>              | <b>\$297 (or \$434 with all optional activities)</b> |

Miscellaneous

- Groceries/snacks: \$55 CAD
- Emergency fund: \$150 CAD
- **TOTAL MISC: \$205 CAD**

GRAND TOTAL COST

| Category            | Cost (CAD)         |
|---------------------|--------------------|
| Accommodation       | \$2,183            |
| Meals               | \$1,470            |
| Fuel                | \$848              |
| Attractions/Entries | \$297              |
| Miscellaneous       | \$205              |
| <b>TOTAL</b>        | <b>\$5,003 CAD</b> |
| <b>Per Person</b>   | <b>\$2,502 CAD</b> |
| <b>Cost per day</b> | <b>~\$334 CAD</b>  |

With all optional activities: ~\$5,140 CAD total

Walking Distance Master Summary

This section provides a at-a-glance reference of walking effort across all key attraction days.



| Day    | Location                                                  | Min. Walking (m) | Notes                                                                    |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 4  | Mount Rushmore, Custer SP, Crazy Horse                    | ~700 m           | All flat/paved if avoiding Presidential Trail                            |
| Day 5  | Badlands + Devils Tower                                   | ~400–900 m       | Drive-up overlooks dominate; one optional boardwalk                      |
| Day 6  | Cody → Lamar Valley → Yellowstone Lake → West Yellowstone | ~280 m           | Lamar Valley is 100% from car; Fishing Bridge + Lake Butte are drive-ups |
| Day 7  | Yellowstone Lower Loop                                    | ~3,500 m         | All flat boardwalks; spread across full day                              |
| Day 8  | Yellowstone Upper Loop                                    | ~1,800 m         | Porcelain Basin + Mammoth Lower Terraces + Artist Point                  |
| Day 9  | Grand Teton — Full Day                                    | ~1,010 m         | 8 iconic viewpoints north → south; longest single walk is 200 m          |
| Day 13 | Chicago                                                   | ~700 m           | Bean + Riverwalk + Navy Pier vicinity                                    |

**Total walking across all major sightseeing days: approximately 8.4–9.4 km spread across 7 days** — well under 1.5 km per day on average.

## Important Notes & Tips

### National Parks Pass

- **America the Beautiful Annual Pass:** \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD)
- Covers 1 vehicle and all passengers — perfect for couples!
- Valid at: Yellowstone, Grand Teton, Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Mount Rushmore, Indiana Dunes
- Purchase at first park (Badlands on Day 5) or buy online beforehand at [store.usgs.gov/recreationpass](https://store.usgs.gov/recreationpass)
- Physical pass ships within 3 weeks — allow time or buy at park
- Keep pass in glove box for easy access at park entrances

### EV Charging Strategy for Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

- PHEV charging planned at: Mackinaw City, Rapid City, Cody, West Yellowstone (3 nights), Sioux Falls, Des Moines, Chicago, Kalamazoo
- All Level 2 overnight charging at hotels (220V, 3–5 hour full charge)
- Cost: Most hotel chargers are complimentary or \$5–10 per session
- Can run hybrid mode continuously if needed — don't worry about charging gaps
- ChargePoint and PlugShare apps — find public charging stations en route
- Electric range: ~35–40 km per charge; use for city driving to save gas
- **Tip:** Request room near charging station when checking in

### Peak Summer Crowds (July)

- July is **peak tourist season** across all parks — expect crowds every day, not just holidays
- Yellowstone: Arrive at each site before 8:00 AM to beat parking congestion
- Grand Teton: Snake River Overlook, Jenny Lake, and Mormon Row are extremely popular — go early or late afternoon
- Badlands: Much lighter crowds than Yellowstone; mornings are still best
- **Start early every day** — the difference between a stress-free visit and a chaotic one is arriving before 9 AM

## Money-Saving Tips

1. **Hotel breakfasts:** All hotels include free breakfast — saves \$20–30/day CAD
2. **Pack lunches:** Buy groceries for in-park days (bread, deli meat, cheese, fruit, snacks)
3. **Gas apps:** Use GasBuddy or Waze for cheapest gas stations (can save \$10–20/tank)
4. **Annual Pass:** Saves \$70+ USD vs buying individual park entries
5. **Off-peak dining:** Eat lunch as main meal (dinner prices are 20–30% higher)
6. **Free water:** Refill bottles at park visitor centres instead of buying
7. **Group discounts:** Ask about CAA/AAA discounts at hotels and attractions
8. **Credit card rewards:** Use travel rewards card for USD purchases (check foreign transaction fees)

## Border Crossing Tips

### Entering USA (Day 1):

- Bring passports (REQUIRED — no exceptions)
- NEXUS cards if you have them (use NEXUS lanes for faster processing)
- Border wait times: Check [cbp.gov/bwt](https://cbp.gov/bwt) before crossing
- Best crossing points: Ambassador Bridge (Detroit/Windsor) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia)
- Peak wait times: Weekdays 7–9 AM, 4–6 PM; Weekends 10 AM–4 PM
- Have hotel address ready for first night
- Declare all food items (no fresh fruits/vegetables allowed into USA)
- **July 4 tip:** Cross early (before 8 AM) — Independence Day brings heavier border traffic

### Returning to Canada (Day 15):

- Duty-free exemption after 48+ hours: \$800 CAD per person
- Declare ALL purchases (receipts ready)
- Alcohol limit: 1.5L wine OR 1.14L spirits OR 8.5L beer per person
- ArriveCAN — check current requirements before trip at [cbsa-asfc.gc.ca](https://cbsa-asfc.gc.ca)

## Weather Considerations (Early–Mid July)

- **Yellowstone elevations:** 2,000–3,000m (6,500–9,800 ft)
- Temperature ranges:
  - Yellowstone: 5–25°C days, -2 to 5°C nights
  - South Dakota: 20–30°C days, 10–15°C nights
  - Chicago: 22–28°C, humid
- Afternoon thunderstorms common in mountains (2–4 PM) — plan to be back at car by 2 PM
- Snow possible at high elevations even in July
- Layering is key: Start day with jacket, strip to t-shirt by noon

- UV intensity is significantly stronger at high elevation (SPF 50+ essential)
- Wildfire season: Check air quality forecasts at AirNow.gov

## Vehicle Preparation & Road Trip Essentials

### Pre-departure vehicle inspection:

- Oil change if due within trip dates
- Check tire pressure and tread depth (including spare)
- Top off all fluids (coolant, brake fluid, windshield washer)
- Test lights, wipers, horn; check battery health
- Verify PHEV charging cable is in vehicle

### Emergency car kit:

- Jumper cables, tire inflator/sealant, flashlight with extra batteries
- Basic tool kit, duct tape, ice scraper (even in summer — high elevations!)
- Tow rope
- CAA/AAA membership: Verify coverage extends to USA

## Cell Phone Coverage — Know the Dead Zones

**Good coverage:** All major cities and highways, I-90 corridor in South Dakota, Chicago area, Michigan

**Spotty/No coverage:** Yellowstone (60% of park has no service — Verizon best), Grand Teton (limited to main roads), rural Wyoming (large gaps between towns), Badlands (visitor centres only)

### Solutions:

- Download offline maps for entire route
- Screenshot hotel addresses/phone numbers
- Print physical itinerary
- Let family know you may be unreachable for days at a time

## Food Storage & Wildlife Safety — CRITICAL

### Wildlife Distance Rules:

- 25 metres (75 feet): Bison, elk, deer, moose, bighorn sheep
- 100 metres (300 feet): Bears, wolves, coyotes
- Use zoom lens for photos — NOT zoom feet!

### Food Storage in Parks:

- Never leave food in open vehicle
- Store in hard-sided containers or trunk
- Use bear-proof trash cans
- Don't eat in car then leave windows down

### If Wildlife Approaches:

- Stay calm, don't run; back away slowly

- Get in vehicle if available
- Bear spray only as last resort (within 7–10m)

## Driving Safety — Mountain & Rural Roads

- Speed limits: Strictly enforced in national parks (45 mph / 70 km/h max)
- Many mountain roads have sharp hairpin turns (10–20 mph / 15–30 km/h)
- Use low gear on descents to avoid brake fade
- Wildlife crossings: Dawn/dusk most dangerous — scan roadsides constantly
- In Wyoming, gas stations can be 100+ km apart — fill at half tank

## Health & Safety

### Altitude Sickness:

- Yellowstone is 2,300m (7,500 ft)
- Symptoms: Headache, nausea, fatigue, dizziness
- Prevention: Hydrate (3–4L water/day), avoid alcohol first 24h, rest frequently

### Medical Facilities in Yellowstone:

- Clinics at Mammoth, Old Faithful, Lake (May–Sept only)
- Emergency: Dial 911 from any park phone
- Nearest hospitals: Jackson (WY), Cody (WY), Bozeman (MT)

## Top 15 Must-See Sites — No Hiking Required

All accessible via car, short walks, or wheelchair-accessible boardwalks:

1. **Grand Prismatic Spring, Yellowstone** — Easy boardwalk loop, most photographed thermal feature
2. **Old Faithful Geyser, Yellowstone** — View from benches, erupts every ~90 minutes
3. **Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point** — Paved 150 m path to iconic waterfall view
4. **Mount Rushmore** — View from Grand View Terrace, 250 m from parking
5. **Badlands Overlooks** — 13 scenic pullouts along Loop Road, all roadside
6. **Mammoth Hot Springs Terraces** — Easy boardwalk loops + drive-through upper terraces
7. **Devils Tower** — View from 200 m paved path from parking area
8. **Mormon Row Barns, Grand Teton** — Drive-up photo ops with mountain backdrop
9. **Cloud Gate ("The Bean"), Chicago** — Walk around mirrored sculpture in Millennium Park
10. **Crazy Horse Memorial** — View from visitor centre terrace, 100 m from parking
11. **Wildlife Loop Road, Custer State Park** — 18-mile scenic drive to see bison herds
12. **Hayden Valley, Yellowstone** — Wildlife viewing from pullouts (bison, elk, bears)
13. **Needles Highway, South Dakota** — Scenic drive through granite spires with tunnels
14. **West Thumb Geyser Basin** — Lakeside boardwalk with colourful hot springs, 0.9 km flat loop
15. **Snake River Overlook, Grand Teton** — Famous Ansel Adams viewpoint, roadside pullout

## Pre-Trip Checklist

3 Months Before (By April 4, 2026)

- ☐ Book all 14 hotel accommodations (especially West Yellowstone for peak July)
- ☐ Purchase America the Beautiful Annual Pass online (optional — can buy at first park)
- ☐ Research and book travel insurance
- ☐ Check passport expiry dates (must be valid through January 2027)
- ☐ Apply for NEXUS cards if interested
- ☐ Book any special dining reservations (Chicago deep dish restaurants)

### 1 Month Before (By June 4, 2026)

- ☐ Confirm all hotel reservations via email/phone
- ☐ Schedule Outlander PHEV service (oil change, tire rotation, multi-point inspection)
- ☐ Check vehicle insurance covers USA travel; verify CAA membership covers USA
- ☐ Download: Yellowstone NPS app, GasBuddy, PlugShare, SpotHero
- ☐ Order physical road atlas as backup
- ☐ Check for road closures (WYDOT, SDDOT) and park alerts (nps.gov/yell)
- ☐ Set credit card travel notifications (July 4 – July 18, USA)

### 2 Weeks Before (By June 20, 2026)

- ☐ Complete vehicle service/maintenance
- ☐ Download offline maps: Michigan, Wisconsin, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana, Grand Teton, Yellowstone NPS
- ☐ Purchase road trip snacks (non-perishable)
- ☐ Start breaking in walking shoes if new

### 1 Week Before (By June 27, 2026)

- ☐ Final hotel confirmation calls (especially West Yellowstone)
- ☐ Print entire itinerary as backup; print hotel addresses and phone numbers
- ☐ Pack bags; test all electronics; charge all devices fully
- ☐ Wash car and clean interior; check tire pressure (including spare)
- ☐ Prepare "car kit" (first aid, flashlight, emergency supplies)
- ☐ Buy cooler; purchase reusable water bottles; stock car snacks
- ☐ Notify neighbours/family of travel dates; arrange mail/newspaper hold
- ☐ Withdraw USD cash (\$200–300)

### Day Before Departure (Friday, July 3, 2026)

- ☐ Full tank of gas; fully charge PHEV battery
- ☐ Check all tire pressures (including spare); test all lights; clean windshield
- ☐ Load luggage into vehicle (leave room for souvenirs!)
- ☐ Set up phone mounts/chargers in car; pack cooler with drinks and snacks
- ☐ Double-check passports are packed
- ☐ Final home check: lights off, thermostat adjusted, stove off, windows/doors locked, garage closed
- ☐ Set alarms for 7:00 AM (depart by 9:00 AM)
- ☐ Get good night's sleep!

### Departure Morning (Saturday, July 4, 2026)

- ☐ Quick breakfast at home; fill coffee thermoses
- ☐ Final house walkthrough; set home security
- ☐ Take photo of odometer (track mileage)
- ☐ Plug in phone navigation; review Day 1 route
- **Departure time: 9:00 AM ET — Let's go!**

### During Trip — Daily Checklist

- ☐ Check weather for next day each evening
- ☐ Charge all electronics overnight
- ☐ Charge PHEV at hotel (if available)
- ☐ Review next day's route before bed
- ☐ Keep receipts organised
- ☐ Refill water bottles; restock car snacks
- ☐ Stretch legs every 2 hours of driving
- ☐ Stay hydrated (especially at altitude)

### Return Home (Saturday, July 18) — Post-Trip

- ☐ Unload vehicle; unpack; do laundry
- ☐ Download photos from camera and back up to cloud
- ☐ Calculate actual trip costs vs budget
- ☐ Share photos with family/friends!
- ☐ Schedule post-trip vehicle inspection if needed

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## Emergency Contacts

| Contact                    | Number         |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| USA Emergency              | 911            |
| Yellowstone Dispatch       | 307-344-7381   |
| CAA Roadside Assistance    | 1-800-222-4357 |
| Poison Control (USA)       | 1-800-222-1222 |
| Canadian Consulate Chicago | 312-616-1860   |

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## Alternative Options to Consider

**If You Want to Cut 1 Day:** Skip Des Moines stop (Day 12) — go directly Chicago from Sioux Falls (~650 km). Saves 1 accommodation night (~\$145 CAD). Total trip: 14 days instead of 15.

**If You Want MORE Chicago Time:** Add extra night in Chicago (2 nights total). Visit: Art Institute, Field Museum, Shedd Aquarium, Navy Pier, Architecture tour. Cost: +\$200 accommodation, +\$100 meals = +\$300 CAD total.

**If Budget is Tight:** Skip optional activities (Wisconsin Dells tour, Chicago observation deck) — saves \$137 CAD. Pack more meals — saves \$200–300 CAD. Could reduce total to ~\$4,200–4,400 CAD.

**If You Want More Nature, Less Cities:** Skip Chicago overnight (save \$200). Add second night in Jackson, WY for extra Grand Teton time.

## Trip Statistics

| Stat                 | Detail                                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Total Distance       | 5,700 km                                                                                    |
| Days                 | 15 (14 nights)                                                                              |
| States Visited       | 9 (Michigan, Wisconsin, Minnesota, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana) |
| National Parks       | Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Grand Teton, Yellowstone, Indiana Dunes                  |
| Average Daily Cost   | ~\$334 CAD                                                                                  |
| Total Estimated Cost | ~\$5,003 CAD (\$2,502/person)                                                               |

*All prices are estimates based on 2026 projections. Actual costs may vary. Gas prices fluctuate — budget accordingly. Book accommodations early for July peak season.*

*Updated: June 2026 — Trip dates revised to July 4–18, 2026. Walking distances and optimization tips added throughout.*

**Have an amazing trip! Safe travels!** 🚗 ✨ 🏡